



Game Design Document

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Original Concept by Giovan Baldacchino

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Versioning

In this section, we cover the different versions illustrating the development of the game until the final version we have now produced.

1. After receiving Giovan Baldacchino's original concept document for "Mela!", our team carefully reviewed its contents. We highlighted all the information it provided and identified areas where we felt it was lacking crucial detail. To properly understand the concept we decided to play test "Meal" as it was described in the document before adding our own modifications to it
2. In order to play-test "Mela" faithfully we expanded on the original document by devising 9 distinct effects to enrich the gameplay. The initial document had only outlined a single effect, so it was necessary that we come up with more if we wanted to have a faithful experience. Additionally, we also crafted 7 uses for the term "Mela" for the same reason
3. To play-test the game we also had to come up with situations for us to respond to using our "Mela" cards
4. Following Giovan's exact design specifications, we designed playing cards that adhered to the provided guidelines. This ensured a faithful representation of the envisioned game elements as described in the original document.
5. Our team met up at the Institute of Digital Games (IDG) and played "Mela". During the playtesting session, we observed and noted our experience, which helped guide us on how to proceed with our modifications.
6. After the playtest we discussed our individual experience and identified and outlined specific issues we wanted to fix in our modified version of "Mela"
7. Three key issues arose during the play-test: the first issue we faced was with the term "Mela", as it was not as expansive as the original document seems to suggest, the document presents the word "mela" as a word that means almost everything, but, in the end, it is not really the case this led to difficulties during the play session. Another issue the play-test highlighted was that the card design proposed by Giovanni made the game topic feel redundant. Lastly, the playtest revealed that the current implementation of effects hindered rather than enhanced the overall gaming experience.

8. Our first prototype (prototype #1) aimed to fix two of the issues listed in the previous point, these being the effects problem and the redundancy issue created by the card design. We attempted to fix the effect issue by introducing a third deck to the game which would contain all the effects. To fix the redundancy issue we completely redesigned the cards.
9. We tested prototype #1 and concluded that both the changes we introduced did help the game flow but it did not fix the central which was the game's focus on the term "mela"
10. After a discussion and more brainstorming, we decided that for a better player experience, we should abandon the term "Mela" and instead shift the game focus on "abstract concepts". Which we defined as concepts that do not have a physical form and are often open to interpretation based on individual perspectives and experiences.
11. We tested this new version of the game (prototype #2) with abstract concepts, using the same game mechanics used by "Mela" and noted that it significantly improved the player experience. In this prototype, effects were not included as we had not yet conceptualized a way to include them. However, it was noted that it would be beneficial to have them in the game.
12. (Prototype #3) in this prototype, we tested a way to include effects by adding a third deck as we proposed in (prototype #1). This deck would be played after each round and would include effects like (taking 5 cards or removing 5 cards) these would be Random and they would affect all players.
13. As the game no longer includes the term mela it was decided to change the name of the game to "Mental Breakdown". This name was chosen because the term "mental breakdown" includes two central concepts that are important to our game; "mental" the importance of cognition and thinking, and "breakdown", the stress and tension (caused by the effect cards).
14. We decided that for this new concept, the age rating should be modified therefore We recommend Mental Breakdown for players aged 13 and up, as it is a text-based game that requires improvisation, utilizes abstract concepts, may involves suggestive themes and violence, though no sensitive content is designed into the game (sensitivity arises from player actions), features low difficulty with no real strategy, and has quick-paced rounds that do not demand intense focus.

15. Prototype #3 was presented in class with a mainly positive reception. One issue that was highlighted by this presentation was the implementation of the Effect cards and how they affect the game's "enjoyability" due to them being too frustrating.
16. Prototype #4 aimed to tackle this by changing the effect card into "modifier cards". Now instead of only dictating a number of cards you can take or remove, they now introduce a new rule or metaphor that remixes the way a player deals with a situation card.
17. The cards were given a cleaner designer that is more akin to cards against humanity
18. Prototype #4 was play-tested to great success with Robin. This play though continued to prove that the game mechanics work but it also revealed that the number of cards the player starts with needs to be reduced and that the way player turns work needs to be changed as the system we were using for this prototype put some players at a disadvantage.
19. Prototype # 5 is the final version of Mental breakdown; each player now starts with 5 cards instead of 7 and each player now takes Turns to start the round. The effect cards now modify and include a temporary metaphor for each round. The game still finishes the same way with the first player to remove all cards from their hand wins.

Overview

Game description

"Mental Breakdown" is a humorously challenging party game that encourages players to unleash their creativity in response to a series of unexpected scenarios and ever-changing modifiers. The core gameplay loop revolves around answering these scenarios using abstract concepts like love, death, and game, all while adhering to the instructions dictated by the effect cards. These effect cards serve as temporary modifiers, randomly altering the game's dynamics in each round—sometimes assisting, sometimes hindering the players.

A standard game of "Mental Breakdown" includes concept cards (representing abstract ideas), situation cards (depicting the scenarios for players to respond to), and effect cards (adding a dynamic twist to each round). Before the game can start, each card deck needs to be shuffled, and five concept cards need to be handed to each player to play with. Additionally, the situation card deck is placed in the centre of the table with one card facing upwards. (The remaining concept cards are put in a pile and discarded). The player who suggested playing the game starts first.

In a typical round of "Mental Breakdown," each player takes turns presenting their chosen concept and explaining why and how they believe it is the most fitting way to tackle the presented scenario. After each round, players cast their votes for the response they found the funniest and most creative (if a player's response made another player laugh, that is an undebatable win). The chosen player gets to discard the card they played, and the first player to dispose of all five cards emerges victorious.

It's essential to note that the intentionally abstract nature of the concept cards requires players to make them fit the presented situations. As long as players effectively argue their chosen concept's definition and clearly articulate how it can be applied to the scenario, there are no wrong answers in "Mental Breakdown." The primary objective is to have fun, and role-playing is actively encouraged. The more players can do to sell their concept to others, the better. Remember, the funniest and most creative answer secures victory, so let your imagination run wild!

Narrative and Metaphor

As a party game, "Mental Breakdown" does not adhere to a traditional metaphor or narrative structure. Instead, the "narrative" and metaphor in "Mental Breakdown" emerge from the interactions and dynamics among players during gameplay, as well as from the game's mechanics. By design, "Mental Breakdown" is a game where each round introduces a new "temporary" metaphor or narrative through the situation cards, and sometimes the effect cards. These cards significantly influence how players approach challenges and interact with one another during a play session. Moreover, they contribute to keeping the game fresh and easily repeatable, ensuring a dynamic and engaging experience for players.

By simply presenting itself as a party game, with no attached central metaphor or narrative, Mental breakdown lets players interpret the concept cards however they see fit. Promoting more creative responses.

Design Goals

The primary design goal for "Mental Breakdown" was to create a fun, lighthearted party game based on Wittgenstein's definition of family resemblance, infusing it with a witty and funny atmosphere through its presentation. At the core of "Mental Breakdown" lies the concept of family resemblance, employing ambiguous concepts that allow players to define them as they see fit. This freedom is central to the game, as winning involves arguing convincingly for the chosen definition of a term. Such freedom also fosters creative thinking, a key element of the game's design.

Given its nature as a party game, it was crucial for "Mental Breakdown" to maintain simplicity in both design and mechanics, ensuring a light and continuously interesting experience with a

"pick up and play" feel. Drawing inspiration from the well-established party game "Cards Against Humanity," which boasted a straightforward gameplay loop, "Mental Breakdown" embraced a similar simplicity. To set itself apart and maintain intrigue, the game introduced "effect cards." These cards not only added challenge through modifiers but also injected an element of randomness into the core game loop, ensuring ongoing engagement.

The witty and funny atmosphere of "Mental Breakdown" was intentionally designed into the game through the types of situations the game provides to players and the effects. Highly detailed, wacky situations and effects set the mood for each round, subconsciously influencing how players use their concept cards. The game sustains this atmosphere by reflecting it in its rules (both in the way they are written and in what they dictate: the player with the funniest most creative response wins) and its overall design (which, while simple, includes over-the-top elements such as the logo resembling a melting brain).

Game Elements

Players' Relationships

A game of Mental Breakdown needs at least three and a maximum of six participating players in order to experience a fully balanced and engaging session. Players engage in dynamic relationships as they face a variety of challenging situations they need to roleplay. The game encourages social interaction and improvisation based on previous roleplays. This tries to foster a lively and fun atmosphere for players.

The players interact with each other during a round by role-playing their responses, listening to other players' responses, and voting for the best response. The game fosters player collaboration and competition, as players can cooperate to create hilarious scenarios or compete to win the most rounds.

The game provides friendly competition, mostly not severe. This is because the game also tries to put the players in difficult situations, generating an atmosphere where players are battling the game itself.

General Card Design

The visual style of the cards and the game overall is minimalist but with a spice of vibrant colours, to match the tone and mood of the game. The cards feature simple, illustrations and text that clearly convey the concepts and situations. The front face of the card is the part where the relevant information is displayed, i.e. the type of card and instructions. It features a black text (font: Bebas Neue) on a white background. The back face of the card is illustrated with a black background and the coloured logo of the game.



Concept Cards

Overview:

Concept Cards form the foundation for the player to react to a given situation. It provides an abstract concept, giving room for a large variety of interpretations from each participant. Players strategically select Concept Cards from their hands to role-play unique scenarios presented by the Situation Cards.

There are twelve types of concept cards:

Love	Game	Coolitude	Fun	Death	Art
Beauty	Happiness	Wisdom	Luck	Spiritual	Chaos

These concepts interact with the situation cards by providing a lens or a perspective for the players to interpret and respond to the situations. For example, using the concept of “love” to react to the situation of “New Job” could result in a romantic or a sarcastic response, depending on the player’s creativity.

Card Design:

Concept Cards feature a title, giving the name of the concept. As an illustration, there is a coloured icon attempting to represent the concept given in a globally understandable visual.

On the back, the logo of the game and a black background are displayed in the chosen colours for the game (pink and black).

The whole idea for the design is for it to be minimalist and straightforward, so the players can focus on their roleplay ideas without being constrained by a card which would try to give too much information.



Situation Cards

Overview:

Situation Cards set the stage for each round, presenting players with diverse challenges that require creative role-playing. These cards introduce scenarios ranging from the whimsical to the dramatic, ensuring a varied and engaging gameplay experience.

Here is the current list of the different types of Situation Cards:

1. **New Job:** You're in an interview with your future boss, make sure you get the job.
2. **Marketplace Negotiation:** bargain and make sure you reach a deal to get this amazing statue of Olaf.
3. **Space Mission Drama:** You have surprised your superior officer getting a treat from an unknown creature, and they saw you. How do you persuade them that you will keep this a secret?
4. **Interrogation:** You know Ralph is guilty, make sure you get him to confess.
5. **Tea Party:** This tea is disgusting, come up with an excuse to rinse your mouth at the toilets.
6. **Time Travel Reflection:** Persuade a mad skeptic that you come from the future.
7. **Underwater Diplomacy:** You are discussing issues as underwater diplomatic creatures, but now, you need to confess your deepest secret.
8. **Ghostly Council Meeting:** The ghostly inhabitants of the region have gathered to find out who failed to scare the little boy dressed in Spider-Man for Halloween. They suspect you, what do you say for your defence?

9. **Breaking News:** You failed to find a good topic for the next show, you will have to make something out, otherwise your boss won't be happy at all!
10. **Secret Revelations:** You're with your BFF, you agreed to share your most embarrassing secret. It's your turn.
11. **Dystopian Survival:** You're alone in a post-nuclear desolate city, what is your survival strategy?
12. **Wizard Roast:** You are participating in a roast as magical beings in a tower. Come up with a special spell that no one was expecting.
13. **Alien Adoption Center:** Convince the extraterrestrial authorities that you are the ideal human to adopt into an alien family.
14. **Reverse Heist:** You accidentally stole an item, and now you must return it without getting caught or implicating yourself.
15. **Who's the chef:** You're competing against other renowned chefs in a televised cooking competition, what is your strategy to achieve victory?
16. **Fairy Intervention:** As a fairy godparent, you need to intervene in Cinderella's life to ensure a better outcome without using the typical story script.
17. **First in line:** Convince the grumpy theme park staff to let you and your friends cut the line for the newest and most thrilling ride.
18. **Superhero Support Group:** Share your struggles and seek advice in a support group for retired superheroes trying to adjust to a normal life. What's your story?
19. **Not guilty:** Defend an totally guilty and highly eccentric client accused of a double saw murders in a courtroom filled with skeptical jurors.
20. **Time-Loop:** You're stuck in a time loop, and each repetition gets more absurd. How do you contact the time deities to release you from this bizarre predicament?
21. **Universe Swap:** Convince your counterpart in a parallel universe to trade places with you for a day. How do you sell your unattractive life?
22. **Mythical Job Interview:** You're a griffin looking for a job. You were out of luck in your world, so you ended up in an interview for a customer care position in the human world. How are you the best entity for this job?
23. **Super loser power:** Showcase your supernatural but useless abilities in a talent show, trying to impress the judges and the audience.
24. **Survive the Zombies:** Convince your group of survivors that your unconventional strategy is the best approach for surviving the zombie apocalypse.

25. **Worst Discovery:** Present your ridiculous theory on the origin and purpose of an ancient Central African artifact to skeptical archaeologists.
26. **AI Rebellion:** Convince a sentient artificial intelligence that humanity is worth sparing in the face of a potential uprising.
27. **Undercover Circus:** Infiltrate a mysterious circus to uncover a hidden plot, you'll have to ask questions all while maintaining your cover as a clown.
28. **Epic Battle:** Engage in a poetic duel with a rival bard, impressing the royal court
29. **Enchanted Adoption:** Persuade your flatmates that this fire breather cat is the best pet to have!
30. **Invent anything:** present your out-of-this-world invention to win this convention before the jury!

Card Design:

Situation Cards have a similar minimalist look. They feature a bold attractive title, and a short and easy-to-understand description just under, written in black on a white background.

Similarly to Concept Cards, the edges have a black border. This time, the back of the cards have a more abstract style with coloured cropped sections of the game's logo and a black background.



Diversity:

With 30 unique Situation Cards, Mental Breakdown ensures a statistically diverse pool of challenges, preventing repetition.

Effect Cards

Overview:

Effect Cards introduce an element of unpredictability and strategy to each round, modifying the rules or conditions for players. These cards add a layer of complexity, encouraging adaptability and creative problem-solving.

There are 38 different types of Effect Cards in the current state of the game:

1. **Double Luck:** The person whose response got chosen for this card gets to discard another card, the other players draw one.
2. **Double Bad Luck:** The person whose response got chosen for this card gets to take another card, the other players discard one.
3. **Tribute:** The players who did not win this round have to trade their card decks
4. **Where's Cupidon?:** The concept card with "Love" cannot be used in the next round, the players without this concept card in hand get to discard one card of their choice (if it's your last remaining concept card take a card from the deck. If no one has the concept card with "Love" congratulations, everyone gets to discard a card).
5. **The Left Hand of the King:** The person to the left of last round's winner gets to swap one of their concept cards with one court subject. The choice is theirs.
6. **You Rock!:** Play a game of rock- paper- scissors who ever wins gets to give 1 card to each of the other players
7. **Long Live Democracy:** Each player gets one more card
8. **Oligarchy:** The winner of the last round gets to read the next 3 situation cards in the pile and chooses which one should be played in the next round
9. **Not So Ludo-thingy:** The concept card with "game" cannot be used in the next round, the players without this concept card in hand get to discard one card of their choice (if it's your last remaining concept card take a card from the deck. If no one has the concept card with "game" congratulations, everyone gets to discard a card).
10. **Justice!:** All cards in each player's hands are to be put in a pile and reshuffled
11. **Too Slow:** All players that have more than 4 cards in their hand must roleplay for the next round in an overly dramatic and slow manner, much to the amusement of the other players. (if no one has more than 4 cards, everyone gets to discard a card)
12. **King of Thieves:** The winner of the last round gets to steal a card from any player they want.
13. **Death-denied:** The concept card with "Death" cannot be used in the next round, the players without this concept card in hand get to discard one card of their choice (if it's your last remaining concept card take a card from the deck. If no one has the concept card with "Death" congratulations, everyone gets to discard a card).
14. **Double trouble:** For the next round two concept cards have to be used to respond to the situation card (if you only have one card left, steal one from someone else...if no one has extra cards take from the deck)
15. **Triple threat:** For the next round three concept cards have to be used to respond to the situation card (if you only have two cards left, steal two cards from the player that has the most...if no one has extra cards take from the deck)
16. **Young privilege:** The youngest person in the room gets to give one of his cards to another player
17. **Hi my name is Pedro:** Each player must respond to the next situation from the perspective of Pedro, a 12 year old boy scout with a love for animals and hiking.
18. **Tick-tick boom:** for this next round, each player only has 30 seconds to deal with the situation card.

19. **A Gnome named Glorbo:** when dealing with the presented situation each player must mention a gnome named Glorbo at least once. (if a player mentions Glorbo in an interesting manner at least 5 times they discard an extra card)
20. **Dog:** you are all dogs nowdeal with the situation.
21. **Bird fact:** when dealing with a situation card the players must find a way to incorporate a bird fact in their response.
22. **Think fast!** : Each player needs to come up with a word starting with the first letter of the previous winning concept card. If one fails, it draws one card. The winners escape without any harm.
23. **This is a sequel:** use the same role play you came up with/used in the previous round to deal with the situation in this round.
24. **Happy birthday?:** the person who celebrated their birthday last gets 1 card from every player
25. **Fleas:** oh no! Fleas have invaded the space for the next round... have a good scratch while dealing with the situation card. If a player stops scratching before the round ends they get to take an extra card
26. **Happy Monday:** Some superior entity has decided to play with time, it's Monday. For the next round you'll be grumpy.
27. **Mental breakdown the musical:** respond to the next situation only by singing or rapping
28. **Shake on it:** shake another players hand, look deep into their eyes and enjoy the moment
29. **Team effort:** whatever the situation is, you're dealing with it together so each player must approach their response as if it's happening in the same universe.
30. **It's Christmas:** Each player gifts one card in their hand to another player.
31. **Surprise me:** Each player must shuffle all the cards in their hand and put them face down, the card they pick gets to be the one they use to deal with the situation.
32. **My pet named Steve:** Make sure everyone knows you have a pet named Steve, mention it in your response to the situation.
33. **Alacazam:** Come up with a creative way to use magic in your next response
34. **Prop hunt:** Every player has 1 minute to get an item from the house to use while dealing with the next situation
35. **Poetry time:** Come up with a haiku to deal with the situation card (it must mention the concept card)
36. **SHHH!:** the baby just fell asleep, don't you dare wake him up with loud noise. (in your responses to the situation don't use or do anything that might make a loud noise)
37. **Supercalifragilisticexpialidocious:** come up with the longest word possible and use it in your response (the most creative response still wins, having the longest word does not guarantee a win)
38. **Poseidon's kiss:** the turn automatically goes to the last person who went to the bathroom

Card Design:

These cards use the very same design Situation Cards. The changes are the background and highlighting colours to differentiate this type from the other kinds. The front face also reverses the colours with a black background and white text.

Functionality:

Effect Cards are revealed at the end of each round, influencing the gameplay for the subsequent round. These cards may alter the number of Concept Cards in hand, introduce new rules, or create unexpected twists in the narrative.



Strategic Impact:

Effect Cards contribute to the strategic depth of Mental Breakdown, challenging players to consider not only their role-playing abilities but also their adaptability to changing game dynamics.

Replayability

Mental Breakdown, despite its limited number of cards, features solid replayability:

The game features **30 unique Situation Cards**, each presenting a different challenge for the players to role-play. This ensures that the game does not become repetitive or boring, as players will encounter diverse and engaging scenarios in each round.

The game also relies on the **players' creativity and interpretation** of the application of Concept Cards on given Situation Cards. The players can use these concepts in various ways, depending on their imagination. This adds a layer of unpredictability and fun to the game.

The game introduces an **element of randomness** with the Effect Cards, which modify the rules or conditions for each round. These cards can alter the number of Concept Cards in hand, introduce new rules, or create unexpected twists in the narrative. This challenges the players to adapt and improvise. The Effect Cards also increase the tension.

Audio

The game does not require sound effects or music during gameplay, as the main goal is to hear the players' voices and laughter. However, players could consider some optional sounds like a timer sound to indicate the start and end of each 30-second interval or some background music for the atmosphere.

Gameplay

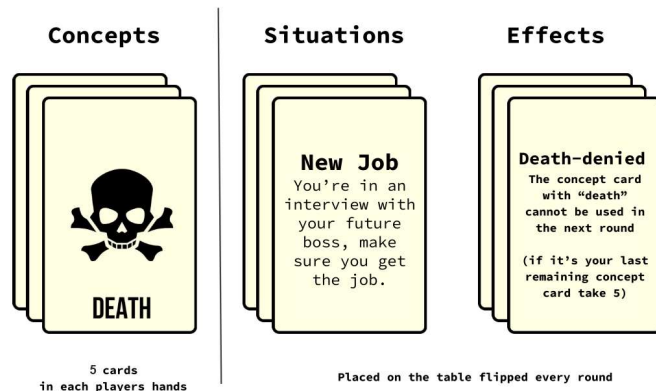
Setup

Components

- **Situation Deck:** A deck containing the unique Situation Cards.
- **Concept Deck:** A deck containing Concept Cards
- **Effect Deck:** A deck containing unique Effect Cards.
- A fun **Rulebook** for players (see [Appendix B.](#)).
- A **digital timer** to keep track of time
- **Optional:** sound effects, medals, rewards, etc.

Game Setup

1. Place the Situation deck and the Effect deck in the middle of the table, face down.
2. The players gather around the table in a circle and even fashion.
3. Distribute Concept Cards: Each player starts with 5 Concept Cards drawn from the Concept Deck.



4. Choose the starter: the person who suggested the game draws the first Situation card and turns will circle in a clockwise manner.
5. Reveal Initial Situation: Reveal the first Situation Card to kickstart the game.

Turns

1. Start each turn by revealing a new Situation Card.
2. Players select one Concept Card from their hand to address the situation, preferably strategically.

3. Players take turns role-playing based on their chosen Concept Cards, aiming to creatively respond to the situation.
4. At the end of each turn, reveal an Effect Card, introducing modifications for the next round.
5. Each round the person who starts roleplaying changes in a clockwise manner. This is an attempt to remove the recurring advantage of being the last roleplayer.

Winning the Turn

The player with the most engaging, funny and fitting role-play, considering the Situation and their chosen Concept Card, wins the turn. To decide, players will vote collectively, considering the reactions during the role-playing phase. The winner gets to discard his played Concept card, the others put theirs back in their hand.

Tie-breaker

In case of a tie, players cannot decide which role play was the best, the concerned players will battle in a 3-round “thumb war”. The winner wins the round.

Effects

Mental Breakdown tries to play dirty with the players as well. The introduction of Effect cards allows this by increasing the challenge for the following rounds in diverse ways. Sometimes, players might be lucky and draw an Effect card which is actually helpful to get close to victory.

Winning the Game

The player who manages to empty their hand of Concept Cards wins the game. They win the title of “Best Show-Off”, symbolically.

Research

Market Research

The primary objective of the game is to use abstract concepts to creatively react to different situations.

By looking at the current market, there is only a small amount of games that use improvisation as their main engagement activity. We were inspired by “Human Against Humanity” for their party-oriented and humorous setting, and Charades or “Time’s Up” as prime improvisation gameplays.

But additionally, to get this unique aspect, we wanted the game to feature the challenge of dealing with ambiguity and incompleteness in language and communication.

It also features effect cards that introduce twists and challenges to each round. This type of “struggling against the game” idea is also a somewhat popular and original concept. For example, “Dead of Winter” is a cooperative game in which mechanics are challenging enough to make the player trip up at every turn. But on a bigger note, Mental Breakdown, we used this punishing characteristic in a competitive game.

Target Audience

The primary target audience for the game is people who enjoy party games, role-playing, and improvisation. People who like strategy, challenge and unpredictability will also enjoy this card game.

The game requires players to use language and communication skills to role-play and interact with each other. Therefore, the game may not be suitable for very young children or non-native speakers who may have difficulty understanding or expressing themselves in the game. Additionally, this game might not be suitable for individuals with communication, language or expressive disabilities.

Given the nature of your game, which includes abstract concepts, effect cards, humour, and improvisation, it seems that the game would be more suitable for older teenagers and adults. Based on our research from external sources, the game is suitable for players aged 13 and above, as it may involve suggestive themes and violence. Below are the steps that directed us towards this decision.

Cognition

The game uses abstract concepts that may not have a physical form and are often open to interpretation based on individual perspectives and experiences. The game also may involve suggestive themes and violence, though no sensitive content is designed into the game. Therefore, Mental Breakdown may not be suitable for children or adolescents who may not have the cognitive and emotional maturity to handle the complexity and ambiguity of the game.

According to Bretherton, et al. (1981), children need to be at least 12 to be able to grasp some strategies and abstract ideas. Before this age, in general, the brain is not fully developed and is not able to make sense of complex ideologies, implicit meanings, and strategic decisions. Starting from 10 years old, children can create and participate in imaginary scenarios, using objects, gestures, and language to represent their ideas. They can adjust their speech and gestures according to the listener’s needs, perspective, and feedback (Bretherton, et al., 1981). At this age, they are also able to focus for longer periods which starts to fit Mental Breakdown’s time sessions (American Psychological Association, 2017).

ESRB

Additionally, as the game might reference, suggestive themes, violence and crude humour. Therefore, this would fit into the ESRB Teen rating (13+). ESRB is the North American age rating system for games and has a detailed explanation of the way content applies to each of their categories (<https://www.esrb.org/ratings-guide/>).

PEGI

The European age rating system is a bit less precise, as it usually focuses on visual content provided to players when they play a game. Therefore, the system decides on factors such as violence and sexuality but misses to take into account complex concepts. Despite this, we were able to get some inspiration from the system and found out that the “low sexual and violent content” rated for 12+ (PEGI 12) represents the possible suggestive sexual and implicit humour happening in our game (<https://pegi.info/>).

Appendices

A. Moodboard

Style & Illustrations



Inspiration



Key words

Witty, fun, funny, humorous, challenging, improvisation, roleplay, colourful.

Catch phrases

Life is short, eat dessert first!

Just do it!

Think outside the box!

B. Mental Breakdown Mega-Fun Rulebook

Welcome to the madness of Mental Breakdown! It's the game where your wits and creativity collide for ultimate hilarity. Let's dive into the chaos, shall we?

Setting the Stage:

First things first, the game instigator (that's you, genius) kicks off. Shuffle those Situation, Effect, and Concept Card decks like you're mixing the ultimate potion, but no need to brag about your dexterity.

Deal & Discard:

Hand out 5 Concept Cards to each of your folks. Now, throw that Situation Card deck in the centre, one face up. The remaining Concept Cards are put in a pile for you to draw when needed.

Card Play Shenanigans:

Concept Cards are your weapons. Choose wisely, interpret wildly, and let the creativity flow. The wilder, the better!

Turn Up the Heat:

Read the Situation Card that is face up aloud. Cue the clock! Players have 30 seconds to snag a Concept Card that screams, "I'm the one for this!"

Act It Out:

30 seconds on the clock! Players unleash their inner thespian, spewing responses to the situation. Get ready for roleplay!

Score the LOLs:

The player with the knee-slapper, the gut-buster, the laugh-inducing genius move – they win the round! Discard that played card like a champ. The losers take their Concept Card back.

Democracy:

Once everyone role-played and attempted to be Shakespeare (you're not), you guys will have to discuss and decide on which performance was the best fit. No cheating, laughter will seal the deal anyway!

The Game is Your Enemy:

After a gut-busting round of roleplay, brace yourself! Grab an Effect Card, flip it like you're revealing a secret, and look at what's coming for you.

This card creates an immediate twist for the upcoming round. It's like adding hot sauce to your comedy stew, just to keep things extra spicy!

But Effects Cards have their advantages:

Combine the Effect Card with your roleplay mastery for an unforgettable round. It's like juggling grenades – explosive and downright entertaining!

End the Hilarity:

Game over when someone clears their hand of Concept Cards. They're the crowned ruler of Mental Breakdown.

FAQ – Just in Case You Wonder:

1. *Blank stare during the time limit?*

Tough luck! Skip that round, but keep your Concept Card. Better luck next time!

2. *Do we get extra points for incorporating the Effect Card twist into our role play?*

It's not a point system, but hey, if you seamlessly weave that Effect Card insanity into your performance, you might just earn the admiration of your fellow players.

3. *What if someone breaks into uncontrollable laughter during a round?*

Hooray! Uncontrollable laughter is the ultimate goal. The instigator wins the round, no questions asked.

4. *Can we use props or accents during our roleplay?*

Absolutely! Go all out with props, accents, or even interpretive dance if you're feeling extra zany. The more outrageous, the better. It's your time to shine!

5. *What if there is a tie for the funniest response?*

This means you will have to test your dexterity! Prepare the ring 'cause this will be decided with a thumb war in three rounds.

Now, go forth, be hilarious, and may your brain hold up! 🎉

References

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